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Nothing Without Love

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Nothing Without Love

1 Corinthians 13

The first few verses of 1 Corinthians 13 became real to me one memorable summer day in 2004. Eighty-two-year-old Edna and I were visiting in her mobile home. For seven or eight years she and I had been meeting regularly to study the Bible and pray. Almost 40 years my elder, Edna was like a mother to me; we weren't afraid to share honestly with each other.

It was hot that morning and Edna sat in her living room sipping an iced tea. I sat facing her holding a glass of cold water. I don't remember what we were talking about, but Edna put her drink down on the glass table between us and leaned forward. Her intense, blue eyes looked into mine. "Mary" she said, "I want to tell you something."

"Okay," I said.

Slowly and deliberately Edna spoke, "Mary, you don't love."

It was Edna's voice, but it was God talking to me.

Instantly I felt the stunning truth of those words. Verses from chapter 13 of Paul's first letter to the Corinthians flashed through my mind. "If I speak in the tongues of men or of angels, but do not have love, I am only a resounding gong or a clanging cymbal. If I have the gift of prophecy and can fathom all mysteries and all knowledge, and if I have a faith that can move mountains, but do not have love, I am nothing" (vv. 1-2).

My life passed before me. I had done many, many good things in my Christian life. As a developmental psychologist, I had worked to help disadvantaged and disabled children. I was being a "good" mother to our four children. I did volunteer work for a mission organization. We went to church regularly, had youth group meetings in our home, gave money to programs for the homeless.

But somehow, in that moment with Edna, Paul's words sank deep into my heart and I understood that in doing these "good" things I was nothing but a "clanging cymbal." Something was horribly wrong with my life. I slumped out of my chair, lay face down on Edna's carpet and prayed, "God, whatever it takes. I want to love You and I want to love people. I don't know what is wrong, but I trust You to fix it."

Read 1 Corinthians 13.

1If I speak in the tongues of men or of angels, but do not have love, I am only a resounding gong or a clanging cymbal. 2If I have the gift of prophecy and can

fathom all mysteries and all knowledge, and if I have a faith that can move mountains, but do not have love, I am nothing. 3If I give all I possess to the poor and give over my body to hardship that I may boast, but do not have love, I gain nothing. 4Love is patient, love is kind. It does not envy, it does not boast, it is not proud. 5It does not dishonor others, it is not self-seeking, it is not easily angered, it keeps no record of wrongs. 6Love does not delight in evil but rejoices with the truth. 7It always protects, always trusts, always hopes, always perseveres. 8Love never fails. But where there are prophecies, they will cease; where there are tongues, they will be stilled; where there is knowledge, it will pass away. 9For we know in part and we prophesy in part, 10but when completeness comes, what is in part disappears. 11When I was a child, I talked like a child, I thought like a child, I reasoned like a child. When I became a man, I put the ways of childhood behind me. 12For now we see only a reflection as in a mirror; then we shall see face to face. Now I know in part; then I shall know fully, even as I am fully known. 13And now these three remain: faith, hope and love. But the greatest of these is love.

Questions

1. In the introduction to this lesson, the author was powerfully confronted by the first verses of 1 Corinthians 13. In what ways do verses 1–3 speak to you personally?
2. Verse 2 speaks of having “a faith that can move mountains.” In what ways does faith express itself in your life?
3. The things described in verses 1–3 seem like “good” things to do. In what ways are they incomplete in what God desires?
4. Recall and describe a time when you did something “good” because you knew it was a “good” thing to do. Your knowledge of how you should behave told you something was a “good” thing to do and so you did it.
5. Recall and describe a time when you did something purely out of love and compassion—because you felt God leading you to do it.
6. Compare the similarities and differences between your responses to questions 4 and 5 above.
7. Identify the characteristics of love mentioned in verses 4–8.
8. Think of someone you know who has these characteristics. Give one or two specific examples of how you have seen this person act with love toward others.
9. Verse 8 says, “Love never fails.” What does this statement mean to you?

0. Read 1 Corinthians 13:4-8 again, this time replacing the word love with the word God (i.e., “God is patient. God is kind.”). Read slowly and thoughtfully letting the fullness of God’s love sink into you. What thoughts do you have about God after reading the passage in this way?
1. Considering the focus of this passage, what do you think Paul is talking about in verses 9-12?
2. How would you define “love” according to this passage?

Reflection

Imagine that God designed a short movie entitled, Love Never Fails (see verse 8). Let the scenes from the movie unfold before the eyes of your heart. See the images, the colors, tones and expressions.

If you feel God is leading you, share your experience.